cast out to space

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/68372541.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by tarifaaa

Summary

Adora consensually (and regretfully) decides to do magic mushrooms and comes to some realizations. Catra comes to the rescue.

Notes

And the Earth looked at me and said "wasn't that fun?"

And I replied "I'm sorry if I hurt anyone"

And without even thinking cast me into space

But before she did that she wiped off my own face

She said better luck next time, don't worry so much

Without ears I couldn't hear I could just feel the touch

As I fell asleep softly at the edge of a cave

I should have gone deeper, but I'm not so brave.

-- When I Was Done Dying by Dan Deacon

You never protected me! Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side!

Well, you are kind of disrespectful .

Admit it! You love being her favorite.

This is a bad trip. The luxury in having a bad trip is that she *remembers* she is tripping. You really can't say that for everything, so she likes to keep that in mind.

The additional luxury is " *feeling the why"* as Perfuma would say. This Particular Why being *Why can't I say no to anything?* The answer, she's learning, is that she's a prideful perfectionist who is untrustworthy and completely unfunny.

Her white under armor is a second skin of sweat and fear. The high is emanating from the pile of slippery intestines coiled around her stomach and pulsing outward in waves of energy. Insects may as well be crawling all over her skin although her hands brush feverishly at her body and come back empty.

The body sensations are nothing compared to the kaleidoscope of shame in her head.

Bow and Glimmer, love them, are terrible trip leaders. They experienced one guided session with Perfuma and were eager to share the experience with Adora because they wanted to connect with her while *tapped into the love of the universe* -- unintentionally creating the conditions in which Adora would not say no. After the first hour of euphoria and shimmering visuals, they have not checked in on her again.

Catra had been offered 1.15 grams as a lower dose.

"High on a drug I've never tried before? For 6-8 hours? With the very people who remember my worst moments?" Catra tipped her head back with laughter.

Bow had put his hands in prayer and closed his eyes, "And more connected to the source of love than ever before."

"I'll pass."

Adora had almost worked up the nerve to back out. She'd admired the ease with which Catra said no to things and thought, maybe, instead of admitting she was scared, she could play the girlfriend card.

"I would love to do shrooms with you guys, but I really shouldn't let Catra be alone while we're all…" She'd gulped. "I'll pass too."

"What?" Catra had bristled. "No, do your thing. I'm fine."

"Uh--are you sure? It's going to be boring. I would never just ' *get high* ' while you're waiting around for us to be normal again. Something could-- happen."

"Adora, I can *take care* of *my* self." Danger cutting her tone. Adora reddened and examined her shoes while Catra pet Melog and breathed. "I'll just take Melog for a walk, maybe call Scorpia, and be back when you're on the decline, okay?"

She'd touched Adora's arm, smiled curtly, and that had been the end of it. Now Adora was certainly on the decline. Memories swelling like ocean tide.

Shadow Weaver's final moments bloom within geometric patterns beneath her eyelids. Disfigured smile, eyes bidding goodbye, unmasked for the first time in their life.

You're welcome .

What was that about? Would Shadow Weaver have saved Catra if Adora had continued on to the heart? Does it matter? Did she feel absolved from it all? Would she have apologized one day had she lived? Adora would *never* process this with Catra for fear of emphasizing their dynamic. Hero. Villain. Weak. Powerful. These concepts rattle around like razor blades in their present-day

relationship, capable of slicing through a harmless comment, yet duller than years before.

Adora breathes raggedly as memories threaten to pull her under conscious awareness. She can feel the memory taking shape and pulling her attention inward. The shapes and shadows lapping with motion and her adolescent thoughts burbling to the surface.

“Glimmer, Bow,” she whispers. “Where are you?”

~~~*~~*

“Hey Adora!” Catra launches onto the mattress where Adora has hitched her unlaced boot. “The last training of the day’s cancelled! Kyle got sick everywhere and he’s on clean up duty.”

“Again?” Adora furrowed her brow. Shadow Weaver had cancelled training last week when it happened the first time. “Are you sure? It’s unlike her to do anything twice.”

The synthetic mattress popples with Catra’s rhythmic knead. *She’s too old to be doing this* , Adora worries as she risks a glance over her shoulder. She wouldn’t care about Catra’s tics if Shadow Weaver weren’t explicit in her direction to discourage them.

“Come on, Adora. Everyone ran off the moment it happened.” She makes eye contact with Adora and taps the mattress. An internal coil tightens and warms the skin of her face. She halts, thrown off

by the swell of attraction, and thinks, this is *intense* . When the feeling passes, the thought vanishes completely.

"Do you think we should go to our spot?" She asks while climbing onto the mattress. Catra butts her forehead and rubs against the side of her neck and face. Adora lifts her booted foot and tugs at the heel, grunting. "It's just-- I hope no one catches us slacking off. Lonnie could really use the ammunition right now."

Catra pulls Adora flush against the wall and climbs into her lap, nuzzling innocently against her shoulders and face. Her purr lulls Adora into a relaxed state, so she lets the thought go and rests her head against the wall. Catra bites her shoulder and settles down for a nap. They'd been doing this for years, and it's a risk every time. Adora's hand wanders to the areas that had been safe before -- her mane, her ears, and the tip of her tail. With eyes closed, she falls into a rhythm and enjoys the sensations of her own relaxation -- the subtle loosening of her jaw, skin around her eyes, and the drop of her shoulders.

Adora is not aware of the time when the shriek of her name rips her from her sleep, "A *dora* !" Her eyes shoot open to Shadow Weaver on a rager. With the lift of her hand, Catra flies into the opposite bunk bed slamming against the metal frame and stays down.

Shadow Weaver rises to her full height and cuts Adora off before she can run to Catra.

“Adora. You missed training.” Her voice is full of emotion. Her mood can feel like a thunder storm before it breaks -- a suffocating humidity cloaked in dark clouds. “You’ve *never* missed a training before.”

She almost sounds like she could cry.

Adora gasps. “I-- Catra said you cancelled!” Catra, who had been holding her breath, released a sigh of defeat. Adora dared not break eye contact with Shadow Weaver to check in on her. “I’m sorry. We won’t ever do it again.”

Shadow Weaver sighs and seems to deflate. Her palm cradles Adora’s cheek and follows up with a slap. Nothing to cry about but enough to communicate her disappointment.

“Okay. Neither of you will have dinner tonight,” she concedes. “It pains me to see you so indolent, Adora. I hope you can turn this around.”

Without sparing a glance to Catra, Shadow Weaver stalks out of the room. Adora balls her hands into fists and digs her knuckles into her eyes. Once. Twice. Her face reddens as she lets out a low keen. She *knew* Shadow Weaver wouldn’t cancel a second time. Catra lets out a low groan as she picks herself up off the floor. Her right eye is already swelling from impact but she’s quick to scramble for Adora’s fisted knuckles.

Adora wails with frustration and pushes Catra off her. 'You *know* how much I hate disappointing her! I *hate* that I listened to you!"

Catra looks miserable from where she kneels on the floor with drooping eyelids. She yawns reflexively, blinks hard, and shakes her head to stay awake. Adora scoffs but lifts her off the floor. "Come on, I'll take you to the medic."

When Catra yawns a third time, unable to pull herself together, Adora wonders if Catra was willing to sacrifice her physical health to get Adora in trouble.

"Catra? You wouldn't try to get Shadow Weaver mad at me, right?"

Catra laughs quickly -- a startled, nervous sound -- and leans into Adora's arms. She seems unable to answer, tail flicking anxiously, which only fuels her inner turmoil. She fumes internally, terrified to show her anger to Catra, but decides after this medic visit that she will avoid Catra for a week or two.

They turn onto the corridor that should lead to the medic and find instead an endless black tunnel cast with stars and celestial bodies. She stops, holding Catra tighter, and startles when she finds Catra's fur is matted black, camouflaging with the starry tunnel. She is a good deal taller than Adora now at this age and older too. Her face is split in half by the black starry substance, pupils a blinding white. She smiles at Adora.

You made me this and it is all your fault.

~~~*~~*

Adora opens her eyes. The sky has purpled with deep evening. For a moment it seems the sky is separated into moveable spheres like a Rubik's cube, stars spinning on an invisible axis. Clouds swirled by the wind into spirals reveal swathes of iridescent planets and moons, a hostile and unfamiliar environment compared to the red sun of Despondos.

Fear and grief well in her throat and threaten to spill out.

"Adora?"

Catra fastens to her side and pets her hair gently. "Glimmer came to find me. I'm here. She said you're having a really tough time." She looks up momentarily as someone hands her a cup of water. "Thanks Bow."

This is Catra, but unlike she's ever seen her before. Her brindle fur seems in constant motion like a collection of molecules organized tightly in the familiar shape and coloration of Catra, but able to reorganize at any moment. Adora had never noticed the dense detail of connective tissue, pigmentation, and blood vessels in her irises. She fears for a second all of that detail will fall away and reveal the terrifying corrupted vision of Catra she had seen in her memory.

“I --” She gags from holding back a sob. “I feel *really* bad.”

Catra’s eyes dilate and her lips soften into an expression of pure sympathy, as though she were looking at a tragic husk of roadkill. She pulls at Adora’s armpits until she’s resting her back against the cave, and suddenly she can see that they *are* somewhere familiar-- the shores of Mystacore. Holding a cup of water to her lips, she helps her drink until Adora can hold it herself.

“If you just keep drinking water, everything will be okay, I promise.” Catra runs a hand down Adora’s arm and presses her thumb against her wrist. “Is touch feeling okay?”

Adora nods and opens her arms for more. Immediately Catra slips into her lap and presses her body against her chest while a deep, rhythmic purr emanates from her. Adora’s hands fall to her girlfriend’s back and press her closer, relaxing into the vibrations against her sternum.

For the first time since this whole experience started, Adora begins to relax. The vibrations take on a pleasurable visual element, lulling her eyes closed as her head falls into place next to Catra’s.

“I’m sorry I blamed you -- when we thought training was cancelled,” She whispers into Catra’s mane.

Catra pulls back to meet Adora’s eyes -- her expression startled, confused, then tender.

“Why are you apologizing right now? What do you need?” Catra prompts carefully, petting her hair again.

“I felt so stuck. That Shadow Weaver might come to hate me felt *real* -- and I was totally out of control when it came to pleasing her. It scared me that I was only ever on her bad side when I spent time with you.”

Adora closes her eyes. “She gave you a concussion and I only cared about myself.”

“You were a child,” Catra whispers and places a gentle kiss at her temple, but Adora’s frown only deepens, seemingly unable to accept the fact.

There might be a more nuanced conversation possible at a time when Adora isn’t riding an intense psilocybin-fueled wave of insight and shame. She can’t seem to accept total blamelessness -- and sure, when Catra and Adora were on opposite sides of a war, she would have loved to see Adora admitting her *part* in the dynamic that had ensnared them in endless nights of tears and licked wounds, but they were children in an unsafe home. That is a fact.

They’d been unable to hear each other for so long -- lost on opposite sides of their own perspective. When Catra finally relented and switched sides, she had needed to do the work to wash away her resentments and confusion and replace it all, over

time, with clarity. For her, that was a daily journaling routine. Being a people-pleaser and a Hero, constantly reassured that your shame-fueled need to please others is *good* , must torture Adora to this day.

She wraps her arms tight around Adora and purrs again, feeling as Adora holds her breath to keep from crying. Her body tension comes to a boiling point. Gently pulling Adora's head into her neck, she waits for the telltale sign of release. Adora gasps and begins to stutter with sobs, melting finally into Catra's embrace.

~~~*~~*

"So… did we feel tapped into the love of the universe?" Bow asks, voice tight with anxiety. Glimmer materializes next to him with a sheepish oversized grin and bags of snacks, which she dumps on a picnic blanket next to them.

Catra and Adora are draped loosely around each other watching the celestial theater revolve above them. Adora's eyes are bagged and red, but her body feels loose from the release of years of tension.

Adora touches Catra's arm and laughs, "I tapped into something, that's for sure."

She looks Catra in the eye, appreciating the minute shifts in expression and dilation as the connection lasts. She can almost feel the mirror neurons firing on the other end.

Catra smiles wryly, “I’m going to start tripping if we keep this up any longer, and we really don’t have the resources for that.”

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